

made medical diagnostics more accessible to households, says Chemmenkoti, the CEO of Metropolis.

HEALTH BURDEN

Government initiatives like Ayushman Bharat, the flagship health insurance scheme, are reducing financial barriers to diagnostic testing. Apart from the pandemic, a once-in-a-lifetime event, India has plenty of other health problems to worry about, including the growing incidence of non-commu-

And this is where diagnostic chains are stepping up. Facilities such as Redcliffe's offer both pathology and radiology services, ensuring quick and clinically reliable results. Many diagnostic centres offer state-of-the-art imaging technologies, including MRI, CT scan, X-Ray, and Ultrasound, and molecular and genetic testing.

JOB OPENINGS RISE

The expansion of diagnostic chains in small-town India is opening

town," says Desai.

Even so, a shortage of skilled personnel, particularly pathologists, radiologists and lab technicians and the still largely unorganised nature of the diagnostics business pose a significant barrier to expanding diagnostic services in underserved areas. The diagnostics business is tilted heavily in favour of Tier I and Tier II cities to the detriment of smaller ones, experts say. "India has roughly 300,000 medical diagnostic laboratories, but only 5,500 qualified pathologists, which is far below global standards," says Chemmenkoti of Metropolis.

The think tank Aspire Circle says the Indian medical diagnostics industry, which typically is urban-centric, employs about 800,000 people and generates three to four direct jobs and three to six indirect jobs per new diagnostic establishment.

Anand K, the CEO of Agilus, says the government should create a Board of Medical Technology to train and certify lab professionals. "Continuous training, annual assessments and licensing are necessary to standardise and develop credibility in the industry," he adds.

Metropolis Healthcare, for one, is tackling such challenges by investing in infrastructure and local talent development. To overcome workforce gaps, the company is focusing on telemedicine solutions, such as telepathology, enabling specialists in urban centres to support remote areas more effectively.

"PPPs, along with advocacy for standardised regulations and skill development programmes, will be pivotal in building a robust diagnostics ecosystem," says Chemmenkoti. **BT**

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80 |

A SHORTAGE OF SKILLED PERSONNEL, PARTICULARLY PATHOLOGISTS, RADIOLOGISTS AND LAB TECHNICIANS POSES A BARRIER TO EXPANDING DIAGNOSTIC SERVICES

nicable and lifestyle diseases and rising population of the elderly.

The most common among such diseases are cardiovascular conditions (leading to heart attacks and strokes), cancer, chronic respiratory diseases like asthma, and diabetes.

These conditions make up a significant health burden, requiring early detection, lifestyle changes and improved healthcare interventions to reduce their prevalence.

"As non-communicable diseases continue to dominate, the need for early and accurate diagnostic services will be crucial for the market's expansion," says Aryaman Tandon, Managing Partner and co-founder of business consultant Praxis Global Alliance.

more job opportunities. Take for instance, Anika Desai, 30, who completed her BSc in medical laboratory technology from Gujarat University in 2016 and worked on short-term contracts in New Delhi with some diagnostic chains before moving back to Gujarat, her home state, in early 2024.

Desai is now employed as a pathologist with Agilus in Navsari, earning ₹6 lakh a year, less than the ₹7-8 lakh she took home in Delhi, but isn't complaining. The company's launch of a sample collection centre in the Gujarat town has, after all, given her a chance to go back home.

"When I learnt about the growing opportunities in my city, I decided to move back to my home-